Leadership Essentials - Study guide

Foundation course | Trainer: Daniel Okafor

About this guide

The habits of good leadership, whatever your title: ownership, clarity and trust.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Take ownership without taking over

- Communicate a clear next step

- Build trust through small kept promises

Leadership is a behaviour

- Leadership is what you do, not your title

- Anyone can lead in a moment

- Small behaviours add up

Welcome to Leadership Essentials. Leadership is often linked to a job title, but it is really a set of behaviours. Anyone can lead in a moment, by taking ownership of a problem, helping a colleague, or making a clear suggestion. That means you can start practising now, whatever your role. In this lecture we cover taking ownership without taking over, communicating a clear next step, and building trust through small kept promises. These are simple ideas, but they separate people others want to follow from those they simply work for.

Ownership without taking over

- Own the outcome, share the work

- Ask before you step in

- Let others do it their way

Taking ownership means caring about the result and following it through. It does not mean doing everything yourself. A common mistake is stepping in and taking over when someone is struggling, which solves today’s problem but weakens the person. Ask before

you step in, for example, would it help if I took a look. And let others do it their way, as long as the outcome is met. Good leaders are comfortable with something done differently from how they would have done it. Ownership is about responsibility, not about control.

Clarity beats charisma

- A clear request has an outcome, an owner and a date

- Say less, and make it specific

- Check that it was understood

Many people believe leaders need charisma. In daily work, clarity matters far more. A clear request has three parts: the outcome you want, who owns it, and by when. Vague requests such as, can someone look at this, usually result in nothing, or in two people doing the same thing. Say less, and make it specific. Then check that it was understood, by asking the person to say in their own words what they will do. This takes thirty seconds and prevents days of confusion. Clear communication is a gift to the people around you.

Communicating a clear next step

- End every meeting with actions

- Write them down and share them

- Follow up on the date you agreed

One of the simplest leadership habits is to end every conversation with a clear next step. At the end of a meeting, summarise what was decided, who will do what, and by when. Write it down and share it the same day. Then follow up on the date you agreed, even if only with a quick message. This habit builds a reputation for reliability. People learn that when you are involved, things move. Many meetings fail not because of the discussion, but because nobody was sure what happened afterwards.

Earning trust

- Trust grows from small kept promises

- Do what you said you would do

- If you cannot, say so early

Trust is not built through big speeches. It grows from small kept promises. If you say you will send something by Friday, send it by Friday. If you say you will raise a concern with the manager, do it, and report back. When you cannot keep a promise, say so early and explain, instead of going quiet. People forgive missed deadlines far more easily than silence. Over time, a record of small kept promises becomes a reputation, and a reputation for being reliable is the foundation of leadership.

Giving credit and taking responsibility

- Share credit generously

- Take responsibility when things go wrong

- Learn out loud

Two habits mark out good leaders. They share credit generously, naming the people who did the work, in front of others. And they take responsibility when things go wrong, saying what they will do differently instead of pointing at others. Learning out loud, such as saying, I made a call that did not work, here is what I learned, shows others that mistakes are survivable. It makes it easier for everyone to be honest. Teams where credit is shared and responsibility is owned tend to be more open and more resilient.

Listening as a leadership skill

- Give full attention

- Ask a follow-up question

- Summarise before you respond

Listening is one of the most underrated leadership skills. Give people your full attention, which means putting your phone away. Ask a follow-up question that shows you want to understand more. And summarise what you heard before you respond. This simple habit slows the conversation down just enough to avoid misunderstandings. People who feel listened to are more willing to share problems early, and to support decisions even when they did not get their way. Leaders who listen well usually know

what is actually going on.

Your next steps

- Use the outcome, owner, date format this week

- Keep one visible promise

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, use the outcome, owner and date format for every request you make this week. Choose one promise to keep visibly, and tell someone about it. Complete the workbook for this course, which includes a clear request template and a promise tracker. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you worked through the course. Leadership starts with small, consistent behaviours, so start with one today.

Glossary

Ownership: Taking responsibility for an outcome and following it through.

Clear request: A request that names the outcome, the owner and the date.

Kept promise: A small commitment completed as agreed, or renegotiated early.

Credit: Public recognition of the people who did the work.